

# WICCA AND WITCHCRAFT

witches in the modern era



## ▲ Cycle of the seasons

This wheel of the year includes symbols of the changing seasons, such as spring flowers, the summer sun, and a plentiful harvest, which reflect the continuous cycle of death and rebirth.

Named after the Anglo-Saxon word for “witch,” Wicca is also called witchcraft or even just The Craft. It is one branch of Neopaganism (see pp.272–275), movements that have adapted old beliefs to modern times.

Wicca takes its cue from the lore and magical practices of almost every age, but as a religion it is less than 100 years old. It was founded in England in the 1940s by an eccentric English former colonial civil servant named Gerald Gardner (see below). He claimed that Wicca was the direct descendant of pre-Christian pagan beliefs. In reality, however, many of its rituals and teachings were created by Gardner himself. Wicca has no central core of established religious practice so,

as it has spread around the globe, it has taken on many forms. These are united only by a shared belief in the benign divinity that inhabits the whole of nature, the idea of magic, and the central creed of “harm none,” meaning do only good. However, sometimes the practice parts company with the theory, as in, for example, the number of Wicca Internet hexes (curses, see pp.300–301) put on political candidates.

## Benign magic in nature

Wicca is generally dualistic (believing in two equal gods). The male deity is often represented as the Horned God. His most obvious manifestation is the sun, a symbol of life and action. The female deity, Mother Goddess or Gaia, the Greek earth goddess, is symbolized by the moon, an emblem of emotion and intuition. By extension, the passage of the seasons, the equinoxes and the solstices, and the waxing and waning of the moon (symbolic

“The first time I called myself a ‘Witch’ was the most magical moment of my life.”

MARGOT ADLER, WICCAN PRIESTESS, IN *DRAWING DOWN THE MOON*, 1979

GERALD GARDNER (1884–1964)

## Father of Wicca

The founder of modern witchcraft, Gardner spent much of his life in Malaya, where the native veneration for magical practices made a lasting impression on him. In Dorset in the late 1930s, he claimed to have been initiated into a local witches’ coven, and he subsequently gave his life over to the furthering of witchcraft. Gardner wrote a series of books that had popular appeal, and he had an instinct for publicity. By the early 1960s, he had achieved the seemingly impossible—the acceptance of witchcraft as an attractive belief chosen as a result of its psychological, social, and community benefits.

